

The Prototyping Cheat Sheet

Every concept, term and guardrail from Lessons 4.1 to 4.7, each with the lever it gives you.

THE FOUR RULES

4.1

Fake data only	No real export, ticket, name or screenshot. Your safety is what is not in the thing , not who hosts it.
Assume public	These tools publish a live link by default. One forward and it is outside the building.
Ask a question	A prototype is a question, not an answer. Built to find out, not to prove you were right.
Plan to bin it	Its job ends the second it changes somebody's mind. Engineers rebuild it properly, and should.

PICK THE TOOL IN FIVE SECONDS

4.2

The question	Does somebody need to use it, or just see it? That is the whole routing decision.
See it → v0	The surface is the argument. Nothing stored, nobody logs in. Builds in React / Next.js / Tailwind / shadcn, so your engineer can lift it.
Use it → Lovable	Something goes in and comes back. Needs a back end. Lovable Cloud adds database, auth and storage in one click.
Neither	One screen and a feeling? Your copilot draws it in the chat in 30 seconds. Also: Bolt (non-React), Replit (no free tier), Figma Make (inside Figma), Cursor (not for prototyping).
Credits	You pay for attempts , not outcomes . A vague brief is literally more expensive.

THE BUILD BRIEF · FOUR LAYERS

4.3

1

Who + the job.

One user, one job, in their words. Lift it from your Module 3 research brief.

2

One screen, one flow.

Name two screens and the path. Every screen you do not name is one the model invents.

3

Fake data, specified.

"8 invented teammates, 3 weeks of cluttered calendar entries." Unspecified means John Doe means template.

4

The fence.

"No login, settings, admin, payments, landing page." The highest-leverage line in the brief, and almost nobody writes it.

1 change at a time

3 tries, then change the ask

decline the back end

NEVER ACCEPT THE HAPPY PATH

4.4

The prompt	"Show me this component in its empty, loading, error and overflow states, side by side."
Empty	The first screen every new user sees, and the most neglected in most products. "No data" wastes it.
Loading / error	What it looks like for the three seconds your API takes on a bad day, and whether failure says what to do next or just "an error occurred".
Overflow	400 rows. A 60-character name. Long strings are where layouts die, and they are never in the mock.
Polish trap	Polish reads as done. A beautiful prototype gets you notes on the blue and a question about the launch date.

THE WORDS, AND WHAT THEY COST YOU

Vibe coding	Describe it in English, the model writes and runs the code, you never read it . Karpathy, Feb 2025. Correct for a prototype, and only a prototype.
Agentic engineering	AI writes it, a human reviews, tests and owns every line. Karpathy's own replacement term, Feb 2026. What your engineers do. Do not claim it.
Happy path	Everything loaded, nothing broken, nobody new. The one state your users are least often in.

MAKE IT TESTABLE · THREE LINES

4.5

The question	Find the assumption that is fatal AND unevidenced . That is the only thing the prototype is about.
The flow	Three steps, no branches. If it is not on the flow, it is not in this build.
The number	"4 of 6 send it without editing." Decided before anybody sees it , or you will not decide at all.
Fake the hard part	Wizard of Oz: hardcode the expensive bit. The algorithm is not the risk; the trust is.
The falsify test	If no result would change your mind, you are not testing. You are campaigning.

RUN THE SESSION

4.6

3 checks first	Anything real in it? Who can open the link? Does anything read as a commitment (a date, a price, a logo)?
Task, not tour	Hand over the mouse, give the task, then stop talking . A presentation cannot fail, so it teaches nothing.
Watch > listen	When SAID and DID disagree, DID is right. "Loved it" plus never finding the button is a no.
How many	Five per user type, fix, then five more. And five tells you if it is usable , never if it is wanted .
Log same day	One line per session, against the assumption. A week later you remember only the two who agreed with you.
Ask	What were you expecting? · When did you last have this for real? · What would stop you? · What would you stop doing?
Never ask	Would you use this? · Do you like it? · Any thoughts? · Does this make sense?

PHRASES THAT SHOULD MAKE YOU STOP

"I vibe coded it"

To an engineer that means **shipped code nobody read**. Say "I built a throwaway prototype."

"Let's paste the real export so it demos better"

This is the sentence that turns a vendor's bad week into **your** bad week.

"Let me walk you through it"

That is a demo. Demos cannot fail. Give the task and be quiet.

"Let's see how it goes and decide after"

No number set in advance means you will read whatever you already believed.

"And it could also..."

The single most expensive sentence in product management.

THE NUMBERS, AND WHERE THEY CAME FROM

2,000+	vulnerabilities, 400+ exposed secrets, 175 instances of real personal data (IBANs, medical records) across 5,600 live vibe-coded apps. Escape.tech, Oct 2025
45%	of AI-generated code samples introduced an OWASP Top 10 flaw. Newer and larger models were no better . Veracode GenAI Code Security Report, Jul 2025
48	days a flaw in Lovable's own API left projects, source and DB credentials reachable. Reported 3 Mar 2026, disclosed 20 Apr. TNW, Apr 2026
~85%	of usability problems found by 5 users, per user type . Real rounds range ~55–95%. Says nothing about demand. Nielsen & Landauer 1993; Faulkner 2003
\$20–25	a month where paid plans start on both tools; both have a usable free tier. PERISHABLE — true Sep 2026, check before you budget